Cohesion: substitution and ellipsis

Understand it

Writers avoid repeating words. They replace a noun with one, a verb phrase with do so, a clause with so or not, or they leave words out (ellipsis). Readers must understand what each replacement refers to.

In Listening, short replies like So do I or I don't think so carry the speaker's opinion: questions often test them.

The rules

- Substitution replaces words: one / ones (I like the blue one), do so (He wanted to leave and did so), so (I think so), such.
- Ellipsis leaves words out when they are obvious: Some students prefer tests, others (prefer) essays.
- Demonstratives: this refers to a single idea; these to several.
- If you do not understand a short word, ask what it replaces.

All the words and forms you need

Noun	one · ones · the same · such (a)
Verb phrase	do so · do it · do that · did too
Clause	so (I think so) · not (I hope not)
Agreement	So do I · So am I · Neither do I · Nor can I · Me too · Me neither
Reference	this · that · these · those · the former · the latter · it
Ellipsis	Some prefer tea; others (prefer) coffee. · I can swim and she can (swim) too.

Where you use it

Reading: Find what 'one', 'so' or 'do so' refers to when answering detail questions.

Listening: Speakers use short replies: I think so. So do I. Neither did she.

Writing: Do not repeat the same noun many times: use this, such or a synonym.

Speaking: Short answers sound natural: I do. I don't think so.

More examples

- I wanted a red car, but they only had blue ones.
- The government promised to act and did so quickly.
- Will it rain? I hope not.
- I love jazz. So does my brother.

- She can't drive, and neither can I.
- Some students prefer exams; others, essays.

Common mistakes

WRONG	RIGHT
✗ I like the red one and the blues ones.	✓ I like the red one and the blue ones.
✗ He said he would leave and he did it.	✓ He said he would leave and he did so.
✗ I am agree. So I do.	✓ I agree. So do I.

Speaking practice: answer using this grammar

1. I like summer. Do you? (answer with So do I / I don't)
2. Will you study abroad? (I hope so / I hope not)
3. Which do you prefer, cats or dogs? Why that one?

Writing practice

Remove the repetition: I bought a new phone because my old phone was broken. My friend bought a new phone too.

Practice

1. Replace: I bought two books. I read the first book yesterday.

2. Replace: She promised to call and she called.

3. Agree: I like jazz. (me too)

4. Disagree: I do not like fish. (me neither)

5. Correct: They want to win and they will do it.

6. What does so mean? 'Will it rain?' 'I think so.'

Answers

1. I read the first one yesterday.
2. She promised to call and did so.
3. So do I.
4. Neither do I.
5. They want to win and will do so.
6. that it will rain